DAVID PARK PHD · EVIDENCE-BASED ENTREPRENEURSHIP · FREE WORKSHEET

Problem Journal Page

VIDEO 2

Find five problems people pay for, wait for or work around in a place you know, then write the one MERIT question you can't answer yet.

From the video "Where Do Good Opportunities Come From?"

M E R I T — **Market, Edge, Returns, Implementation, Team**
Five questions every business has to answer.

HOW TO USE THIS SHEET

1. Pick a place you know better than most people, such as your job, a hobby or your neighborhood.
2. This week, write down five problems you see people there pay for, wait for or work around.
3. For each one, note what people do about it today and what has changed lately that could make a better answer possible.
4. Star your favorite, and write the one MERIT question you can't answer about it yet.

1 Five problems, in a place you know

A homemade fix or workaround is the strongest sign, because nobody builds one for a problem they don't really have. Star your favorite.

#	The problem (who struggles with what)	Pay, wait or work around?	What they do today	What changed lately?
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

2 Your favorite

The problem you starred Copy it from the table

The one MERIT question I can't answer yet Market, Edge, Returns, Implementation or Team. Write it as a question you could go and find out.

How could you find out, cheaply? Something you could do this week, before you spend real money

REAL COMPANY

Gymshark began with a workaround. Ben Francis, a student who lifted weights, couldn't find gym clothes that fit, so he started making his own in his family's garage. The problem is lifters who can't buy fitted gym clothes, what they do today is make their own, and what had changed is that he could reach the lifters he looked up to on YouTube. The MERIT question to answer first was Market. Would other lifters pay?

THE TRAP

A real problem is where an opportunity starts, not proof that it's a good one. That's what your one MERIT question is for.

WHY THIS WORKS

In baby products, more than eight in ten of 263 companies were started by people who used the products, mostly parents (Shah and Tripsas 2007). In medical imaging, ventures started by medical professionals and patients outlasted other entrants, on average (Park, Rha, Shah and Chattopadhyay 2024).

Next video: Who Should Be Your First Customer?

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